

AVACHERRYNORMALISED-1

Travel Radio World, and we are very honoured this month to have with us Ava Cherry, who is a fantastic artist in the United States and around the world really, and I have her on the line from Chicago. Ava, welcome to the program. Thank you very much.

Hello Radio Australia. Yes, and soon to be around the world in America as well, so it's great. And Ava, you are an artist, you play soul, you're a singer, you've worked with some of the greatest names in the music world.

Can you tell us a bit about how you got started in the music industry? Well, I mean, it's kind of a long story. It sort of started from, I was a model and I worked in Europe and everything like that. I worked quite a bit in Paris and some places in London and did some magazine work and some runway work.

But I was introduced initially, well, I was friends with Stevie Wonder, and even though I never did a record with Stevie or anything like that, Stevie's kind of was my introduction into the world of R&B music and whatever. A girlfriend of mine was dating him at the time and I had a manager who, I moved to New York from Chicago, and my manager came up to me, he goes, I need you to listen to this record. It was a Ziggy Stardust.

This artist, David Bowie, I think he's going to be huge in the world and he's going to come here for a tour soon. And so I said, okay, well, why do you want me to listen to it? And so he was like, well, I just think he'd be interesting for you to listen to. I think it was fate that my manager handed me this record that I didn't know why it had something to do with me.

Anyway, to make a long story short, I listened to the record. It was an incredible record. And I said to myself, this guy is something unique, changed my life.

The next thing I knew, he was performing at Radio City at the same week that Stevie Wonder was at. And I was at Stevie's concert and Stevie said, well, we need to give a party afterwards. Where should we give it? And I was working at a club called Genesis.

I said, why don't you give it at this club? It was a really upscale disco. So they did give it there. And guess who showed up? I was standing there and my manager runs over to me and says, you know that guy, David Bowie, gave me this record.

He's here in this party. And then that's how I was introduced to David Bowie. And you actually went on to collaborate with David Bowie and got very close to him.

And I've been reading your background and you collaborated and you're one of the backup singers on Young Americans. That is an incredible achievement. And oh, yeah.

And it must have been a very special time when you when you went through all that. It was very

special. It was well, when I met him, he goes, well, I love, you know, I love your look.

I love your image. And I was singing with Stevie and a bunch of people at the piano. And he goes, are you a singer? And I said, well, I'm a singer, but I'm not on the professional level yet.

He goes, well, I'd love you to go on tour with me in Japan. And that was how that started. And the next thing I knew, I was in the studio with him.

I mean, well, it took about a year later because a lot happened in between. I don't know if your audience has long enough, but there's a lot of stories if they want to read about me in the Internet. But anyway, to make a long story short, by the time we got to Young Americans, yes, that was where we met Luther Vandross as well.

And he brought Luther Vandross onto this recording project. The times back then were were incredibly changeable, weren't they? And we miss all that time when you had such a huge range of music that people were into. And you must have been absolutely thrilled to work.

And your relationship with Bowie was was very close after a while. You got to know the man very, very well. Yes.

Yeah. I mean, I was thrilled and I was I was David's muse. I will say that in part of the pop culture, because David came to me.

I mean, I helped advise him, especially when we were getting ready to do Young Americans, because I was living in London with him. And he was like, well, I want to do this soul record. What do we do? What do we do? And I said, we got to go to we got to go to New York where, you know, in a place like the Apollo, where there's 10 different great soul artists, R&B artists performing all at once in one night even.

And so that was what happened. He sent me on to New York and then he started talking to people in New York about, you know, how to get, you know, go to the Apollo, look at some bands so that we could form a band for the Young Americans project. And since then, you've had an incredible life.

You've moved on. You've moved on from that and became a soul artist yourself. And you were on the soul circuit right around the United States and around the world.

Yeah. I mean, then when I wasn't working with David anymore, I started working with Curtis Mayfield, who is one of the most prolific producers, artists that's ever been here in Chicago. He produced some tracks on my first record.

Love is good news and you never love me. So, yeah, I worked a lot with some of the greats. And then Luther Vandross became huge after David Bowie and I toured with him as well.

What an incredible name in soul and jazz, Luther Vandross. I think I actually saw him in New York just playing in a really small piano bar in New York once. And he's that kind of guy.

I think he likes to do that sort of thing. You know, he's not really, oh, I'm a superstar. He just loves to play and perform as do yourself.

Oh, yeah. I mean, because Luther would like do background sessions. I mean, Luther did a couple of background sessions for me where he actually just sang background, arranged the background vocals.

I mean, his whole thing is he just loved to sing and he loved to arrange the vocals and everything that which he was a master at. So it was a great honor also to work with Luther Vandross. And then there's a documentary out about Luther called Never Too Much, which I'm in a whole lot.

It actually shows me from the very beginning of working with with Luther until the end for him, where, you know, there's so much footage of me when we first started. It was an incredible experience, really was. But the experience of working also with somebody like John Lennon, because we did fame in Electric Ladyland in New York.

It was kind of funny that day because David was so nervous to meet John Lennon. And he was like, I mean, he was I've never seen him so excited about any artist except John Lennon. I mean, he was excited about the artist Mick Jagger and whatever.

But John Lennon, he says to me before John showed up for the session, he said, I wonder if John really wears those granny glasses everywhere. And so the doorbell rings. We're in the studio and the doorbell rings and he opens the door and I'm behind him.

And then there's John in the granny glasses and he turns around to me because, oh, my God, it was such a fantasy and a dream for him to be in the studio with John playing, replaying across the universe. I think it's a better version than the original version that he did of it. And just being able to myself sing on on fame, which is at the end, which is fame, fame, fame, fame, fame.

And that's me, John Lennon and David Bowie. Wow, that's that's just incredible. You're so much part of the world music history.

And one other thing I wanted to ask you about a couple of things. You were actually present at one point at the Playboy Mansion with Hugh Hefner. And you were actually there.

Can you tell us a little bit about that? And I was there before David Bowie. I mean, I worked there. I worked in the mansion.

The main one initially was here in Chicago on State Parkway. I was just a kid. I was only like really 16 and a half.

The only reason that my mother let me work there was because she worked for Playboy. She worked in the building. She worked in the actual administration building.

And so I met a couple of the young ladies that were there and they were much older than me. They were like 18, 19 or whatever. And they were like, oh, you need to come to the mansion.

Hefner gives a dinner every Sunday and a film that's not been shown yet, and then I started going. And then, you know, Hefner was like one of these people that loved to play backgammon and all that other stuff. And I was kind of a bold, clever bitch at the time.

You know, I would I would I wasn't afraid of anything or anyone. And they were all afraid to, you know, really talk to him. And I would sit next to him while he was playing backgammon.

And one night I was sitting there and after I'd been, you know, to at least five or six dinners and I said, OK, I guess I better go home. It's getting late. And Hefner looks over and he goes, well, I just live here.

You're here all the time anyway. And that was what happened. I ended up living there.

But I'm going to say one thing. I've got to say this. Hefner was a wonderful man.

He was I mean, he had his sex with his girls, whatever. Whoever participated in that, they wanted it. I mean, and believe me, they were well compensated and paid for anything that went on with him.

But he never bothered me about anything. He never bothered anybody that did not want to be involved. And he was a good person and he was a nice guy.

He never pushed it on anyone. So that's what I can say about him. Yes, he was never accused of anything wrongdoing.

It was all consensual with adults. And yes, yes. And what are you doing now? What is your current situation? Well, I'm actually I'm actually recording new music and I've been like, you know, touring and I was just in Amsterdam with Big Frankie, Cult TV.

So, you know, I'm looking forward to doing other things. I'm also I also do voice over and commercials and everything like that. So I'm doing that.

Actually, I'm preparing for an audition today. I'm going to be performing in Amsterdam on January the 10th for the anniversary of the passing of David Bowie, the Dutch David Bowie group with Raius Brarda, who is the lead singer, who is a wonderful singer. Wonderful.

Well, it's an incredible story you have. Great thing is you're still performing and you're still really that you still have that fantastic passion for soul music, disco music, all that sort of thing. And oh,

yeah.

And the fact that you've been on those magnificent albums of Bowie is just incredible. And I think the world really has huge respect for you, Ava. And it's so wonderful that we can, you know, highlight you on Travel Radio World and I really appreciate that.

I really appreciate I really appreciate that because, listen, nothing is promised to anyone. And the whole thing is to stay in the game. And I say to people that are trying to be in the business, you stay in the game, you stay true to it, you stay professional.

You just don't stop. You don't let anybody stop you if you believe in yourself. I really believe that.

And I feel like now I've actually been given more on my plate than even in some past years that I can't even believe it. My sweet mom just passed away a couple of months ago. And she said to me before she said, thank you.

She said to me, you keep going. You don't stop. You don't you don't stop for anything or anybody.

You just keep going and doing what makes you happy and doing great things in the world and contributing to people being happy through music and art. How can people find out more about you online, Ava? Oh, you can go to any all the mediums. And, you know, I have a record, the record that I did with Curtis Mayfield.

That's out right now. Love is good news. You know, the Ava Cherry official.

You can go to my website, Ava Cherry official, the Ava Cherry on Instagram. I'm all over the place. I'm on every medium that you can imagine.

And we're so looking forward to you actually doing interviews for Travel Radio World in the United States. And we're really looking forward to that because you have so many contacts with the music industry and great people in entertainment. And it's wonderful to have you on board with us, too.

Oh, that's wonderful. Yeah, I'm looking forward to that because the one thing that I'm looking forward to working with, you know, with you, Jeff, and around the world, interviews with different artists, because it's one thing I do know about myself and I, you know, allow other people to say whatever is positive about me and that I believe in myself. I know how to talk to people.

I know how to bring people in and make them understand and be interested in what I have to say. What I have to say right now is to be positive, to peaceful resistance in everything, to just keep going and do it for yourself, but for the world, because right now we need that love in the world. We need to push everything for love and peace in this world right now.

Ava Cherry, it's been an absolute pleasure to have you on Travel Radio World and Travel Radio

Australia. Have a lovely day and we look forward to hearing. Thank you, Jeff.

Thank you, everybody. Thank you. Peace and love forever.

Okay.